My suggestion? If your spouse has a broker, get a financial planner. If your spouse has a financial planner, get a broker. If your husband has an account at the local bank, open your account elsewhere. Now you've got independence *and* diversification—the best of both worlds.

At some point in your life, you have to pass the tipping point where you stop paying interest to others because you are in debt and you start collecting interest and dividends because you have begun to invest. Your nest egg and the income it provides are what you are going to live off when you get old and crusty!

Investors are always asking me how they can avoid paying fees to have their investments managed. You can't. The investment advisory business is a multibillion-dollar industry. None of the people in it work for free. If you elect to use a broker or financial planner, you should know with certainty that they are going to get paid a fee to perform their services. The key is to get your money's worth.

A good investment advisor forces you to diversify your investments. Diversification is so important in investing, yet so many people suffer devastating losses by not implementing this simple strategy. You probably know someone who fell in love with a stock as they watched it soar in value and come to represent a large percentage of their net worth, only to ride it all the way back down as the company blew up. Remember Nortel?

I made this very mistake in my early days as an investor, but I learned the hard way and now I possess a steely discipline that is forged from the searing flames of experience.

I have already shared with you in my first and second books some basic rules that have saved my portfolio many times over the last few decades. But here is a new and more complete summary of some of my investment philosophy.